with the job of trying to prepare the army to face the Chinese when the need arose.

The prime minister's attitude towards Thimayya was damaging to the chief as well as the army. A whispering campaign started that speculated on the 'rather trivial' reasons for Thimayya's resignation. That the chief was unhappy with the defence minister's insistence on promoting certain officers was a well-known fact and pre-dated the Longju incident. It was hinted that the 'temperamental differences' were a direct result of this difference of opinion. General Thimayya was, by all accounts, a seasoned, disciplined soldier who would hardly have made issues over trifles. Only overriding national interests could have provoked him to take this step. Further, as a disciplined soldier he had accepted his prime minister's assurance and withdrawn his resignation. From the day he had taken charge, Thimayya had been focused on redressing the various problems that faced the Indian Army, especially the evolving civil-military equation where the army seemed quite removed from the decision-making process on matters relating to defence. However, he found himself up against a wall in the form of the Ministry of Defence, which was either indifferent or hostile to his moves. After the resignation drama Thimayya was seen as an alarmist and a defeatist. Having thus weakened the office of the army chief, the prime minister now placed his hope in the man he believed had all the answers. In the corridors of power in New Delhi, it was Lieutenant General B. M. 'Bijji' Kaul whose star was on the rise.